### Chico Mendes



Born in 1944, the son of one of the 50,000-strong “Rubber Army” who tapped rubber for use in the Allied war effort in World War II, Mendes started work as a rubber tapper at the age of nine. Influenced by priests from the progressive Liberation Theology movement, he helped found a branch of the Workers’ Party and became leader of the Rubber Tappers’ Union.

As large areas of Brazil’s rainforest were cleared to make way for cattle ranches, Mendes publicized the tappers’ fight to save the forest. He went to Washington, D.C., to persuade Congress and the World Bank that cattle-ranching projects should not be funded. Instead, he proposed that forest areas be protected as “extractive reserves”—public land managed by local communities with the right to harvest forest products sustainably. Cattle ranchers saw his movement as a threat, and one, Darcy Alves, shot him dead in 1988. After his death, the first of many such reserves was established, covering 2.5 million acres (1 million hectares) of forest around Xapuri.

## The rainforest

Destruction of the rainforest poses a severe threat to global biodiversity because it has been estimated that between half and two-thirds of the world’s plants and animals live in this environment. Between 1.5 million and 1.8 million species—mostly insects, followed by plants and vertebrates—have already been identified in rainforests, and many others have yet to be discovered and described. In Borneo, Indonesia, for example, an area of